

Conflict Zone

Space crunch and slipshod Government efforts are squeezing the tigers out of Ranthambore

Last month, two 16-month-old cubs of the Ranthambore National Park were poisoned by locals and since then wildlife officials and tiger lovers have been debating whether these deaths could have been avoided. Certainly, it could have been, only if the Centre had not halted the shifting of tigers from here to Sariska or any other spacious sanctuary, following a demand from an amateur lobby. "We could have prevented their deaths only if the relocation had happened as planned," rues R.N. Mehrotra, chief wildlife warden of Rajasthan.

The twin murders not only reduced the already dwindling population of the big cats but also convinced forest officials that human-animal conflict still exists. Their conclusion got stronger a few days later when a tiger mauled to death Badri

Kumar, 50, making it second human killing in five years. "Ranthambore is demanding space," says wildlife activist Raj Pal Singh.

Ranthambore has been left with just 282 sq km of core area, and another 1,112 sq km declared as buffer zone with people living in it. Now authorities want to increase the core area but that needs shifting out 73 villages and about 10,000 families. Although Rs 102 crore has been sanctioned for voluntary relocation, it is easier said than done. Last year, 33 families were shifted out which created 60 sq km more space, enough for just one tiger. This year, there is a plan to relocate five more villages to add 300 sq km of space. One of the main ideas behind expanding the core areas was to open Ranthambore to nearby sanctuaries—Kela Devi



CONSTRUCTION ACTIVITY IN RANTHAMBORE SPELLS DOOM FOR ITS TIGERS

GETTY IMAGES

and Sawai Mansingh—through corridors.

However, the lobby demanded that tigers must be examined for their DNA and genetic compatibility to rule out any inbreeding at a new place. This led the Centre to halt the relocation plan that was even corroborated by Wildlife Institute of India, Dehradun. Experts are of the opinion that tigers in any case have been mating amongst themselves in Ranthambore or in any other reserve, and still

have robust genetic patterns. "Science can wait but not the life-threatening crisis of space," says Mehrotra. This protest has, however, let the Centre to allow the relocation while genetic analysis is being done simultaneously.

A spurt in construction activity inside the park and the rising number of tourists are also reasons for tigers leaving their territory. To save the tigers, the initiative has to come from the Government.

by Rohit Parihar

to hunt. They travel by train and even ticket collectors are too scared to confront them for travelling for free. They are always successful in the hunt and poorly equipped and poorly trained forest officials and guards seem powerless to stop them. Last year, 43 people were sentenced in the Katni forest division for poaching and supplying animal parts to international poachers Qureshi and Darya Singh. Property worth Rs 2 crore was seized from Qureshi. Last month, the gravity of the problem was highlighted by no less than the prime minister himself, who wrote a personal letter to the chief ministers of five states urging them to

act more forcefully in saving the tiger from poachers.

His concern is timely. In 1989, in the wake of Project Tiger, India's tiger population was 4,334. By 2001-02, it had dropped to 3,642. Today, it is down to a shocking 1,411 tigers spread across all of India, the lowest since the Independence. The INDIA TODAY investigation shows that the impunity with which the Pardhis operate is scandalous and an eye-opener. The obvious answer is not in India's hands, namely to crack down on the insatiable market

for tiger parts and skins in China, where it is used in traditional medicine or as an aphrodisiac.

The Chinese, however, can only be pressured by international organisations dealing with wildlife protection. The Pardhis, as our interaction revealed, are hardcore criminals who also happen to be skilled trackers and hunters, a deadly combination. The alarm bells have been ringing long enough. If the concerned chief ministers and forest officials fail to act, our children may never get to see one of the world's most magnificent animals and our national symbol, in its natural habitat. ■